likely plants from China, vocally urged concessions to Beijing, using social media to spread their message. Meanwhile, US allies in Asia sought to prevent an outright breach between the two giant nations, but at the same time saw advantages in having both Beijing and Washington attempt to curry favor with them, whether through lessening demands on them, offering trade blandishments, or elevating diplomatic exchanges.

All this took its inevitable toll on the publics of both nations. At the 20th National Party Congress of the Chinese Communist Party, in November 2022, Xi stayed on as paramount leader, which was widely expected, and inserted a plank seen as a preemptive declaration that China would seek hegemony over the South China Sea by 2049. Public opinion polls taken in 2024 showed that the number of respondents in China and the United States having a positive opinion of the other country had dropped to single digits and that each considered the other its number one potential adversary. In short, the political relationship between the United States and China had deteriorated to such a degree by 2025 that relations seemed nearly unsalvageable.

II. The Antebellum Military Balance

As relations worsened, military planners in both countries stepped up their contingency and operational planning. While few professional military officers believed they would face the other side in actual combat, their responsibility lay in ensuring that their political leaders had the most complete set of military options available and that their forces were trained and equipped for potential conflict.

The subsequent events of the war depended in large part on the military balance that held between the two at the outbreak of hostilities. For the United States, it was the first time it had conducted large-scale military operations in Asia in a half century, since the end of the Vietnam War. For the PRC, its last full-scale conflicts had been the 1962 Sino-Indian War and the shorter but intense 1979 border war